Jihadi networks are often self-perpetuating and, thus, not self-contained; nodes within them either have ties to or may be seeking to connect with other outfits or networks. As a network grows, this is more likely to be the case. For example, Seifullah Chapman was in touch with another American named Mahmud Faruq Brent al-Mutazzim. Brent was not part of the Virginia Jihad Network (he lived in New York), but had also attended a Lashkar camp in 2002. Once back in the US, Brent introduced Chapman to his roommate, Tarik Shah. Notably, Brent described Chapman as a recruiter for training camps overseas.[169] Shah and another Brent associate, Rafiq Sabir, were aspiring jihadis interested in making contact with al-Qaeda. The two of them later pledged bayat, an oath of allegiance, to Osama bin Laden during what they believed was a meeting with an al-Qaeda recruiter, but who turned out to be an undercover FBI agent.[170] By the time Shah helped the FBI to bust Brent in a sting operation in 2005, the latter no longer maintained strong connections to Lashkar. Nevertheless, he pleaded guilty to providing material support to Lashkar, while Shah and Sabir were sentenced to prison terms for proffering material support to al-Qaeda.[171]

The growth of the internet during the early years of the decade contributed to the proliferation of networks among established and would-be jihadis, facilitating virtual connections across countries and continents. In addition to connecting the worldwide jihadi community, it also served as a vehicle for radicalizing a new generation. The growth of online jihadi forums and the explosion of accessible propaganda enabled established actors to reach a greater audience than ever before. The internet also provided aspirant jihadis with a seemingly anonymous space in which they could engage in ‘risky behavior,’ which in turn led to the rising threat of homegrown terrorism in Western countries. Yet although the threat of online radicalization was real, it often took contact with established activists or militants to give virtual recruits the final push toward violent action. Further, despite the profusion of instruction materials that could be found online, there was no substitute for training with professional militants, a function Lashkar remained ideally placed to offer as a result of its protected position in Pakistan. Its physical networks also meant that online recruits could contact established activists in the West who in turn facilitated access to the group.